

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 1236

By Love

A RESOLUTION to honor and commend the Tennessee State University Tigers on winning the Ohio Valley Conference Tournament and earning a berth in the 2026 NCAA Division I Men's Basketball Tournament.

WHEREAS, it is fitting that this General Assembly should salute those student athletes who have distinguished themselves as true champions while proudly representing historically Black colleges and universities; and

WHEREAS, the Tennessee State University men's basketball team has earned a berth in the 2026 National Collegiate Athletic Association (NCAA) Division I Men's Basketball Tournament and will play in the Midwest Region; and

WHEREAS, 2026 marks Tennessee State's first NCAA Tournament berth since the 1993-1994 season, when the Tigers won their second of back-to-back Ohio Valley Conference (OVC) Tournament championships thanks to the talent and leadership of two-time OVC Player of the Year Carlos Rogers; and

WHEREAS, Tennessee State secured a share of the 2025-2026 Ohio Valley Conference regular-season title with a 15-5 record, thus earning the No. 1 seed in the conference tournament for the first time in thirty years; and

WHEREAS, the Tigers handily defeated UT Martin and then routed Morehead State to claim the OVC Tournament title and punch their ticket to the NCAA tournament; and

WHEREAS, Tennessee State is led by OVC Player of the Year Aaron Nkrumah, who paced the Tigers throughout the season as the team's primary scoring threat, while ranking among national leaders in steals; and

WHEREAS, he was joined on the All-OVC First Team by teammate Travis Harper II, and Dante Harris was named to the All-OVC Second Team and OVC All-Newcomer Team, tying the program's highest single-season total of all-conference honorees; and

WHEREAS, this tremendous trio combined to average 46.8 points per game during the regular season, helping power Tennessee State to an overall 23-9 record and one of its most successful campaigns in decades; and

WHEREAS, Nolan Smith has made an incredible impact in his first season as Tennessee State's head coach and has been recognized nationally for his coaching prowess; and

WHEREAS, Coach Smith has been named a finalist for the Ben Jobe Award, Joe B. Hall Award, and Hugh Durham Award; these honors recognize the nation's top coaches at historically Black colleges and universities, first-year head coaches, and mid-major programs, respectively; and

WHEREAS, the members of the Tennessee State men's basketball team epitomize all that is good in today's student athletes, as they have achieved a premier level of success in competition while exhibiting the highest degree of character in all aspects of life; and

WHEREAS, the members of this General Assembly find it appropriate to acknowledge and applaud the Tennessee State University Tigers for their outstanding season on the hardwood; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that we honor and congratulate the Tennessee State University Tigers on winning the Ohio Valley Conference Tournament and earning a berth in the 2026 NCAA Division I Men's Basketball Tournament and extend to them our best wishes as they represent the Volunteer State in March Madness.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.